



KenAKAFrosty / Prns



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Accountability & Misconduct #241

Closed



markqvist opened 1d ago



In [#240](#), [@jackspace](#) states:

I found it by accident

Did you, *really* [@jackspace](#)?

Because both this, and [#238](#) coincides very conveniently with the publication of both [the initial look at the Prns development practices, benchmark fudging and misleading marketing](#), and the [subsequent addition of it](#) to the [Brandolini's Reference](#) chapter of the RNS manual.

At least now, you cannot claim not to know.

For anyone involved in this project, I would highly suggest reading the overall information contained in that chapter, since it contains information that will be of personal and legal relevance to contributors, maintainers and downstream consumers of the Prns project.

I am also incredibly curious to know who of you personally "own" these? (According to the wording of your own contribution policies)

I am choosing to be *very* forthcoming here, in lieu of the alternative, more directly "process-oriented" option available at this point.

If the exploration of the basic concepts of what a software license means and does was not entirely clear in the above chapter, [a more concrete elaboration is given here](#)

Given all the legitimate questions and well-documented problems that were raised in:

- [A Gentle Look at Prns](#)
- [The brief Prns inspection](#)
- [The Brandolini's Reference thread](#)
- [Ken's original advertising of Prns](#)

I think you owe the Reticulum community some clear, honest answers [@KenAKAFrosty](#), instead of [spreading uncertainty and distortion](#) and conveniently ["forgetting" everything that has already been said on that subject](#), intentionally reducing and "forgetting" several years of discussion so you can claim that *"Even framing it as an "issue" is entirely against"* my intentions, when in reality I have engaged with the matter repeatedly, extensively, over years.

The truth of the matter here, in absence of any other reasonable explanation, is that you are performing tactics to [further a narrative](#) that seeks to legitimize [genuinely destructive behavior](#), for your own personal gain, while claiming you are "working for the whole world".

A **very** substantial amount of genuine, well-founded criticism has been raised against your project, and your conduct [@KenAKAFrosty](#). Instead of raising to the challenge of answering to it, you have been rallying people on social media with very dubious claims, feigned ignorance, and projected narratives.

From what I can evaluate, trust in the Prns project, from the Reticulum community, is severely damaged, if not completely broken at this point.

Instead of taking the direct legal route, I want extend a chance to you to make this right.

What this requires should be pretty clear from the documentation provided.

If you would rather discuss any details with me in private, or have questions for clarity that require confidentiality, you have my contact details, and you can reach out at any time.

Take your time, I'd rather you read and understand the base of the matters here, instead of feeling rushed and just feeding everything into a machine. If you answer, it's *your* answer that I am interested in, not a synthetic one.

Sincerely,
Mark



markqvist 1d ago

Author



And really, do take your time. These are serious issues, and warrants thinking over and considering. I have other work to do, and won't be returning to this for at least a week anyway. It has already taken up enough time as it is.



tonymcowan 18h ago

Contributor



What's your ask, Mark?

Was all that to say, "Hey, you forgot to put a particular form of copyright attribution in some particular place"? Why not ask?

I expect you believe you're somehow acting in the general public interest, but I haven't seen any specific example of how our project harms anyone. Who are you protecting, from what? Do you have evidence it is harming someone's network? Is anyone making money from this work we do for free? Did we misinterpret your words "... building what comes next is not my responsibility anymore. It's yours.". No one here has been rude to you and you have no business attacking this project with baseless FUD.



Repository owner locked as resolved and limited conversation to collaborators [3h ago](#)



KenAKAFrosty 3h ago

Owner



A lot of words written. Very little actually said.

The only thing even remotely coherent is the general sense of unease about my motivations or my background.

So let's go on that journey. It's not that deep.

~

At the beginning of this year, my significant other was diagnosed with stage III breast cancer. I took a sabbatical, so that I wouldn't have tremendous external obligations while helping care for her.

While caring for her took much of my time and focus, I did still have some spare time of course. And what does a career software engineer do in their spare time? Tinkering, hacking, and learning!

That's where Reticulum came up.

"Oh, this system seems really intriguing, and thoughtfully built." I saw cyptographic keys as addresses, which due to experieence with [Iroh's work](#), I saw good value in. And then that with the combination of medium-agnosticism & mesh features? Wow, this sounds worth exploring!

So, like many others, I started to think about developing an application on top of it. But also like many others, I quickly ran into limitations with doing so directly on top of the reference implementation. The issues with performance and portability were quickly becoming roadblocks even in early prototyping.

Well, is that it? Dead on arrival? That's what I began to think.

But it turns out the author, Mark, seems to have passed the torch to the community, just a few months prior in [the latest post on his website](#). He said:

■

If you want Reticulum to continue evolving, you have the power to make that happen. The protocol is public domain. The code is open source. Everything you need is right here. I've provided the tools, but building what comes next is not my responsibility anymore. It's yours.

Powerful words. Hope is restored!

And, great news! I must've not been the only one to think so, because it seems like there are a lot of community efforts to build implementations in other languages, with other APIs, focuses, or specialties.

Great! They're a little rough around the edges, but I'm totally fine helping work on them if the authors seem open to collaboration. By the time I need to start integrating the library, it should be good enough at least for early iterations.

Onward!

Then, the next roadblock: learning resources were very thin. This isn't even a criticism; it's pretty understandable. Maintaining that kind of documentation, or learning materials, is a lot of work on its own. And, hell, consider that most recent public message: this is an understandably tired open source maintainer.

Okay, I'll have to dig in more deeply to learn at all. No problem, and hey maybe I can help close the gap on learning materials too! That's even what led to me beginning to work on the structure of a small series [on YouTube](#) to help in that effort.

Now, the manual gave some information, but is a bit thin in terms of the API surface and so on. Clearly this will take some digging into some source code.

But another roadblock.

Around this time it's also becoming clear the other implementations won't really meet the needs of what I had in mind. And hell, it's not their responsibility to!

So, dead in the water again? Well, no, but it'd mean having to make my own implementation now. That's a much different kind of undertaking..

Thankfully, there's more good news on that front!

The manual, just like that author's community call-to-action post, says the protocol is public domain, and has been since 2016. And then the RNS readme itself says

The reference implementation is the final, authoritative specification.

Compatibility with the Reticulum Protocol is defined as having full interoperability, and sufficient functional parity with this reference implementation. Any specific protocol implementation that achieves this is Reticulum. Any that does not is not Reticulum.

Fantastic! Clearly that means we'd have a solid testing oracle, the live reference implementation itself!

Plus, since there's no formal specification anywhere, to even establish "What is the Reticulum protocol?" enough to build an implementation of it, the author simply points entirely and wholly to the Python reference implementation.

So, a choice:

Move on from all this, or make my own implementation?

I chose the latter. And figured, "Well, this might help some others in the community! So if I'm going to take all this on, I might as well open source it too. If I'm experiencing the friction and roadblocks that led up to this point, surely others are too. And with the author clearly stepping away and putting the onus on us, the community, this feels like the right thing to do".

So there I am, in full good faith, spending time, focus, human creativity, and genuine care, working on Prns. Using modern development tooling, part of which includes AI tooling. All of which I was open about. All the while just simply trying to solve the real engineering problems to give more options to community.

There is no conspiracy. No evildoers. Just a guy solving some engineering problems.

Not to mention during this time, I was still active and engaged and helpful in the community. I assumed everyone else was also operating under good faith.

Silly me.

Finally it was far along enough to have a good API shape such that outside contributions and development could be reasonable without too much of the library and its API shifting around underneath them. Still clearly released as early, still explicitly pre-1.0 software.

I announced it on Reddit, and that forum. The two tight, niche communities specifically around Reticulum that I assumed would most benefit from it.

I figured many of them were plenty fine using RNS and wouldn't care or need the differences and benefits that Prns offered. Meanwhile those who were in a similar boat, and did need the things Prns offered, would have that option now.

Silly me.

The pages and pages and pages of just hysterical vitriol that I received was absurd. No actual meaningful technical complaints or discussion, mind you. Other than a really great point from bergie about making sure the websockets would interop with the community. Which I went on to implement shortly after.

What I witnessed was an entire group eschewing all scientific thought, care for engineering, and technical curiosity, all in favor of the joy of writing poetic vicious replies. The cruelty was the point.

I was treated terribly in that forum post. To the point that even members of that community, in that very thread, said so openly.

But that was your space, and you have every right to do or talk about what you want in that space.

So while I was blindsided by that experience, I ultimately realized it was just a mismatch; I didn't really understand what that community stood for, and after that experience, I now do.

So I moved on, and simply continue to work on Prns. C'est la vie.

However, you are now (for the second time) bringing that caustic energy here.

It is not welcome.

It will never be welcome.

I have not done anything remotely wrong. The only hostile thing here is **you**.

I'm locking and closing this issue accordingly.



 **KenAKAFrosty** closed this as completed 3h ago

Add a comment



This conversation has been locked and limited to collaborators.



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